thought that the darogahs of every town should take a census of the inhabitants and throw out ‘the do-nothings, the mischievous, and the bad’. Ibid.

. Abul Fazl writes in the *Ain-i-Akbari* (vol. 1) that improvement in ‘the condition of man’ depends ‘on the advancement of agriculture, on the order kept in the king’s household, on the readiness of the champions of empire, and the discipline of the army’.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. As the historian A.L. Srivastava puts it, Harkha ‘exerted great influence on Akbar and his policy’. See A.L. Srivastava, *A Short History of Akbar the Great (1542–1605)* (Shiva Lal Agarwala & Co., 1957).

. Editors’ introduction to Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate*.

. Banarasidas, *Ardhakathanak* (A Half Story), trans. Rohini Chowdhury (Penguin Books, 2009).

. The Jain monk, writes Pushpa Prasad, was able to win over the brahmins: ‘Vijayasen Suri proved from the Jain scriptures the falseness of the accusation and convinced the Brahmans, Shaikhs (Muslim scholars), the emperor and others, that the Jain conception was similar to that expounded in the Samkhya philosophy of the Brahmans.’ See Pushpa Prasad, ‘Akbar and the Jains’, in *Akbar and His India*, ed. Irfan Habib (Oxford University Press, 1997).

. The historians add that Akbar asked Guru Amar Das to pray for him during the siege of Chittorgarh. See editors’ introduction to Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate*.

. Iqtidar Alam Khan, ‘The Nobility under Akbar and the Development of His Religious Policy, 1560–80’, *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society of Great Britain and Ireland*, no. 1/2, April 1968.

. Ibid.

. Munis Faruqui argues that this final change in Akbar’s policies (not only with regard to the jizya but the rule of his diverse realm) was influenced far more than is usually admitted by his half-brother’s defeat (in 1581) and subsequent death (in 1585): ‘Once rid of the menacing shadow cast by Mirza Hakim, Akbar no longer felt compelled to tailor his imperial initiatives to woo disparate political and religious constituencies. Indeed, the death of Mirza Hakim, I argue, is a hitherto overlooked element in the exploration of how and why Akbar conclusively moved from a pro-Islamic stance to the liberal and eclectic stance for which he is widely remembered.’ Munis D. Faruqui, ‘The Forgotten Prince: Mirza Hakim and the Formation of the Mughal Empire in India’, *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient*, vol. 48, no. 4, 2005.

. ‘He was singular for theoretical and practical knowledge,’ writes Abul Fazl (*The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3).

. Translator’s note in *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

. Ibid.

. Translator’s introduction to *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

. Translator’s note in Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*, trans. W.H. Lowe. Richard Eaton notes that Humayun, too, had adopted the ritual of a darshan at dawn – ‘showing his face to the public just as the sun showed itself to the king’. Humayun also gave pride of place to the sun on his ‘courtly carpet’, where it was coloured gold and placed at the very centre of all planets. Richard M. Eaton, *India in the Persianate Age: 1000–1765* (Allen Lane, 2019).

. The figure of the eternally ‘oppressed brahman’ makes more than one cameo appearance in the chronicles of Akbar’s reign. In 1586, one of Akbar’s generals, Qasim Khan, marched into Srinagar and discovered yet another prophecy of this kind. Some 900 years previously, the story goes, Kashmir was ruled by ‘wine-sellers’ – a community of low or no caste, presumably, for a brahmin called Shiv Dat was terribly ‘distressed by the vogue of the polluted’. Shiv Dat decided to summon a ‘baital’, a spirit, for help. This was no small matter: the ritual involved sitting on a human corpse